



Security Watch

WPA Not So Protected

The Problem

Two German graduate students have discovered a way to break Wi-Fi Protected Access (WPA) in about 15 minutes.

The Solution

Switch your router to use WPA2 protection. If your router doesn't support it, upgrade its firmware and try again.

Facebook Enemies

The Problem

According to a new Websense alert, spammers have started sending out emails that seem to come from Facebook, and tell you that one of your friends has approved you. This email comes with a ZIP attachment, which installs an assortment of nastiness on your PC. However, now you'll more likely get an email with a link to what you'd think is your friend's profile, but will install more malware.

The Solution

First, check where the email really comes from. In Gmail, click on Show Details, or click on the little arrow next to Reply and choose Show Original.

Acrobatic Trick

The Problem

Hackers can now use a specially made PDF that causes a stack overflow in Adobe Acrobat and/or Reader, and gives them the same rights to your PC as you have.

The Solution

No solution has been released for this problem. You can bet that you'll be safer if you didn't open PDFs you didn't ask for.

using local bandwidth, which your ISP pays much less for. If the server is on the ISP's own network, they pay almost nothing and in turn you pay almost nothing.

We may need to wait a while before we have Indian mirrors for the sites we access every day, but if our ISPs implement P4P, there will be little to separate us from our pirated (and some legal) content, and they can't whine about how much we're costing them. Now, we just have to get rid of that download limit.

ZTICING IT TO HACKERS

IBM Keeps Your Identity Safe

Do you get nervous when you shop online? Did you say, "No, thank you" when your bank asked you if you wanted netbanking? Are you worried that there's someone out there just waiting for you to mess up and release your credit card information online? Well, there is. If IBM has their way, though, they'll be waiting a long time.

Viruses have come and gone, but no security breach has had the kind of mileage that phishing, and the subsequent identity theft has. You can't be safe from your own gullibility, so it's ridiculously easy to fall for a phishing attack. At

the same time, though, we can't really afford to go back to the days of standing in queues at our local bank branches (well, maybe, but do we want to?). Now, IBM's Zurich lab has come up with a solution to all our woes, and it's called ZTIC — Zone Trusted Information Channel, and pronounced "stick." The ZTIC will protect you from a *man-in-the-middle* attack, where you think you're talking directly to your bank's server, but you're really talking to a hacker's machine, and that machine is talking to the bank's server. So you could be requesting a transfer of Rs 2,000, but the hacker can transfer Rs 20,000, and still make it seem to you that everything's all right.

Here's how the ZTIC protects you: you ztic it into your USB port, and it starts communicating directly with your bank's server using a secure connection. Meanwhile, you use your browser for netbanking, just as you would in any other circumstances. While you're going about your transactions, the ZTIC will show you the amounts that the bank's servers are receiving, so if there's a difference between what you see on screen and what the ZTIC shows you, you'll know that it's a *man-in-the-middle* attack, and hit the big red button to kill the transaction. It's like the SMS you get after you use your credit card, only in real time.

There are, however, many ways that the determined hacker could get past the ZTIC — most obviously, get the ZTIC to talk to his *man-in-the-middle* server



HOT

Android
It's got swipes, a Webkit-based browser, it's open source, and it's the first real competitor for the iPhone's OS. Also bundled: all the Google-y goodness you'll ever need. In your pocket.

NOT

One Phone?
The G1 is probably the ugliest and most ungainly phone on the market. Period. If Android is open source, why didn't more manufacturers want to use it on their new phones? All we can do now is wait for Motorola to come up with their Android phone.

as well. Secondly, the ZTIC doesn't protect you if you've got key-loggers installed on your system, and may even lull you into a false sense of security.

If your bank gives you an RSA SecurID (a little keychain that generates a random number every minute or so), you probably don't have to worry about needing the ZTIC — in fact, the SecurID can't be fooled by a *man-in-the-middle* attack. What we really need our banks to do before anything else is to stop writing bad, IE-specific code. Then bring on the SecurID.

NO TV FOR YOU!

Gadgetry That Cuts Your Bills

No, we're not going to blather about new, green technologies that consume less energy and more money — not in the sense you'd expect, anyway. While "green" tech